

Memories of the Great Art Boom

TO CALL THEM THE GO-GO YEARS WOULD BE AN EXERCISE IN understatement. Between 1986 and 1990 (a period punctuated by the plunge in stock prices), the art market seemed to be in the grip of a buying panic. An art dealer friend who was in the thick of things now likens the frenzy to the manias and delusions that beset society every so often. (I don't remember him speaking this way at the time.) confrontations between characters of great ego and enormous wealth finally led to a stunning hyperinflation of prices, particularly for the works of the more celebrated artists of the past 150 years. The emblematic numbers for the period were the \$53.9 million paid for Van Gogh's "Irises" in 1987 and the \$51.7 million for Picasso's Blue Period "Pierette's Wedding" in 1989.

But at every level prices were bid up proportionally. My friend instanced an American painting that had been sold for less than \$10,000 in 1969. It was resold for almost \$1 million in 1989. This spring it is on the block again, with an estimated price of \$150,000 to \$200,000.

By the fall of 1990 the buyers had disappeared. Action at the auction houses became routine as prices groped for a bottom and prospective sellers kept the best works off the market. Artists who had been raising their prices year after year suddenly stopped selling. The great art boom had come to an end. they must look back on those years with amazement ■

NEW YORK — The once red-hot photography market is suffering severe growing pains. And that's good news for savvy collectors.

In the late 1980s, as the art boom was lifting prices of paintings, a swelling crowd of museums, corporations and individuals who could no longer afford the best paintings were furiously snapping up the best photographs. Photo prices, like painting prices, skyrocketed. The very best ones routinely cracked \$50,000, a phenomenal amount given the large supply and reproducibility of photographs.

New Favorites

Now, the photo boom has subsided. Photography's price record of \$181,000, set last year for a photo by Russian avant-garde artist Alexander Rodchenko, hasn't been approached in subsequent auctions. The high prices for photos had brought out

Last September, a routine estate appraisal uncovered a paragraph written by Abraham Lincoln with the phrase "With malice toward none, with charity for all." Christie's, the auction house, pegged its worth at \$500,000—then sold it to a successful bidder for \$1.3 million.

Unlike fine art, where prices slid during the recession as cash-crunched owners liquidated their holdings, autographs and manuscripts are seldom thrown wholesale on the market and tend to hold their value.

The political collectibles market should stay bullish

an avalanche of supply, depressing the value of photographs recently sold.

The silver lining for collectors? A soft market for photography means bargains in prints of the best photographers like Ansel Adams, and in sectors that experts bet will be the hottest of the 1990s.

Dealers say that as rumors hit the market that Weegee was to be the subject of the 1992 movie "The Public Eye," starring Joe Pesci, prices of his garish photos soared to nearly \$10,000 each.

And now? Experts say Curtis photos are likely to appreciate even further because his market is broad-based; the buyers include not only photography collectors, but also collectors of Western and Native American historical material.

But "the Weegee market has crashed," says Julie Nelson-Gal, head of the photography department at San Francisco auction house Butterfield & Butterfield.

At the recent New York auctions, most of the Weegee photos didn't sell or sold below their estimated price.

The sales indicated that prices are still holding up for photography "Old Masters" such as Edward Weston and Edward Steichen. But they also showed that, in retrospect, collectors apparently feel they paid too much in the past for oft-seen Ansel Adams views of a rising moon; those shots have fallen in price to between \$10,000 and \$12,000, from as much as \$20,000 three years ago, says Robert Persky, editor of the Photograph Collector newsletter.

Japanese Struggle Through Art Hangover